

1.3 Headphones

Most of us make the mistake of thinking that it's only through speakers that you can *really* listen to music. The fact is that the high-end headphones of today, though expensive, reproduce sound with such high fidelity that your experience with one of them might make you a convert! Two points are in order here:

- Using the headphone amplifiers we'll talk about, your hi-fi headphones can actually sound like speakers, with all the spatial effects.
- Sealed and noise-cancelling headphones are great for commutes and such, and also when you want to listen to music with *no* ambient sound. These are especially useful in situations when you cannot afford to pump up the volume on your speakers, such as when you're listening at night.

Here we talk about four headphone sets in particular, and about headphone amplifiers in general. You can order this equipment from headphone.com and some other sites, as well as from ebay.com, but do remember the added shipping charges, as well as the import duties.

Many audiophiles argue that the best listening experience is provided by audiophile-grade headphones, *not* speakers! Audiophile-grade headphones tend to be “open” headphones. Open headphones allow the sound waves to propagate away from the ear freely. This means you're not isolated from outside sounds, and besides, sound through open headphones can be easily heard by others in your vicinity. But as a result of their open nature, they sound more “expansive” due to the lack of resonance: the sound isn't cramped between your ear and the headphone cap.

To expand on this further, the closed headphones you're probably used to, are sealed, which attenuates the sound waves that propagate away from the ear. The reproduced sound is therefore not nearly as accurate. The sealed chamber that is created reduces the “soundstage”—the area between two speakers that appears to